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“AUTHENTICITY IS THE ANTIDOTE TO GREENWASHING”

It hurts consumers and honest businesses investing in cleaner processes, better materials and measurable impact

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► **THERE WAS A TIME** when a green leaf on a packet, earthy colours in an advertisement, or a vague promise of being “eco-friendly” was enough to suggest that a brand cared for the planet. Sustainability lived in annual reports and glossy campaigns, but not always on the factory floor, in the supply chain, or inside the balance sheet.

That era is ending.

Greenwashing—the exaggeration, concealment or misrepresentation of environmental benefits—is no longer a harmless marketing flourish. It is now a consumer protection issue, a regulatory risk, an investor concern and a test of corporate integrity. The central question now is: can you prove what you claim? In India, too, that question has legal and commercial significance.

In 2024, the Central Consumer Protection Authority issued guidelines to prevent and regulate greenwashing and misleading claims. They require verifiable evidence. The Advertising Standards Council of India has also required green claims in advertisements to be specific, substantiated and not misleading.

This shift matters because sustainability has long suffered from

a vocabulary problem. Words such as “green”, “natural”, “clean”, “carbon neutral”, “conscious” and “sustainable” are often used without explaining what improved, by how much, over what period, and against which baseline. A bottle may

sustainable product gets lost in the noise. Greenwashing hurts consumers and honest businesses investing in cleaner processes, better materials and measurable impact.

It also weakens trust. If environmental claims are seen as corporate



ESG HAS SEEN HYPE AND BACKLASH, BUT THE INVESTOR QUESTION IS VALID: IS A FIRM MANAGING LONG-TERM RISKS, OR MERELY ITS IMAGE?

be called eco-friendly because the cap is recyclable. A building may be marketed as green because it has solar panels. A fashion brand may promote one sustainable line even as the larger business depends on overproduction and waste.

The problem arises when language runs ahead of reality.

Consumers are more aware today, but also more vulnerable to sophisticated claims. When every product claims to be green, the genuinely

theatre, people become cynical about genuine climate action. That is dangerous when India needs private investment in clean energy, circular economy, water efficiency, sustainable packaging and climate-resilient supply chains.

The business case for moving to genuine green action is compelling. Regulation is catching up. Consumer law, advertising standards, securities regulation and global supply-chain rules are converging around disclo-